MOREH NEVUCHIM

Asked for His Essence, Shown His Ways: The Rambam on the 13 Attributes

Given Tuesday 20 October 2026 · Moreh Nevuchim I:21, Part 2

Sefer: Moreh Nevuchim (Rambam), Chelek Aleph — Rabbi Chaim Makbili's Hebrew edition / Sefaria

Chapter: I:21 — **עבר** (to pass), Part 2

Topic: The five meanings of **עבר**; the Rambam's preferred reading of **ויעבר ה' על פניו ויקרא** — Hashem *diverting* Moshe from His "face" (His essence) to His "back" (His ways); why the Thirteen Attributes are not thirteen parts of God; what this means for bowing and for how we chant the verse; the danger of reaching too far, and **ושכתי כפי עליך**; and **Onkelos**: the Shechinah passing in Moshe's presence, read either as a created light or as a prophetic vision

Schedule note: The Moreh continues every Tuesday, 8:00–9:00pm (tonight ran to 9:05 to finish Onkelos). Chapter 21 will be finished next week, perhaps with the short Chapter 22 as well.

Recap

Chapter 20: רם and **נשא**, high and exalted, can mean physical height or exalted status. Used of Hashem they never mean He is physically above or located in the heavens; they express His **greatness, authority and power**. We went through **Yeshayahu 6:1**, six words of which we have now explained, to see how learning the Moreh changes our reading of Tanach.

Chapter 21, introduction (last week): Shemot 33 — Moshe asks to see Hashem's face; Hashem says *you can see My back*, and *I will put My palm upon you and protect you*; the words **מקום** and **נצב**; Moshe carves the luchot; **וירד ה' בענן ויתיצב עמו שם ויקרא בשם ה'** — Hashem rests His presence permanently with Moshe; and then **ויעבר ה' על פניו ויקרא: ה' ה'...**

The four questions:

1. What does it mean that **Hashem passed**?
2. **Whose face** — Moshe's or God's?
3. How do we read it — **ויקרא ה': ה' אל רחום** (*Hashem called*: "Hashem, merciful God..."), or **ויקרא: ה' ה' אל רחום** (*He called*: "Hashem, Hashem...")?
4. What are the **Thirteen Attributes of Mercy**?

The Road Map for Chapter 21

Five meanings of עבר, and then **four interpretations** of **ויעבר ה' על פניו**, each using one of those meanings:

#	Interpretation
1	**The Rambam's own, preferred reading**
2	**Targum Onkelos**, understood one way (2A)
3	**Targum Onkelos**, understood another way (2B)
4	**The Rambam's own reading using the Targum's principle** — a completely different interpretation (next week)

Each one changes how we read the parts of the verse — and really the whole narrative and the whole chapter. Once we have them all, we will read the story again under each, and make a chart comparing all four.

Part One — The Five Meanings of עבר

Before reading: the Rabbi asked the class for meanings.

- *To pass.* — Yes, on the simple level.
- *The past* (עבר), as opposed to the future. — That is the same as meaning one: the past is what has *passed*.

Avram passed through the land. — Still meaning — (this week's parashah) **ויעבר אברם בארץ** one.

Meaning 1 — Physical movement across space

משמעותו הראשונה היא כמשמעות "עבור" בערבית, והיא תזוזת גוף במרחב; ודוגמתו הראשונה העברת בעל חיים על פני מרחק מסוים.

A body — human or animal — moving across a space, from one place to another:

והוא עבר לפניהם (Bereishit 33:3) — Yaakov went ahead of his family and bowed to Esav.

עבר לפני העם (Shemot 17:5) — Hashem tells Moshe, before he strikes the rock: walk in front of the people.

Why not ויעבר אברם בארץ? The Rabbi doesn't know. The commentators spend a long time on why the Rambam quotes this pasuk rather than that one, and in this order rather than that. It is part of the depth of the Rambam, but to do it for every verse we would be here forever; it is beyond the scope of the shiur.

Meaning 2 — The spreading of sound

אחר כך הושאל להתפשטות הקולות באוויר.

ויעברו קול במחנה לאמר: איש ואשה אל יעשו עוד מלאכה לתרומת הקדש, ויכלא העם מהביא (Shemot 36:6) — "They passed a voice through the camp" means **a** *stop bringing for the Mishkan.* **proclamation**: a public announcement.

כי לא טובה השמעה אשר אנכי שמע מעברים עם ה' (Shmuel I 2:24) — Eli to his sons, whose corruption we know: *the rumours the people of Hashem are passing about you are not good.* Not walking anywhere: **talking**, reverberating.

Meaning 3 — The light and Shechinah prophets see in a vision

This week's parashah, Lech Lecha.

אחר כך הושאל להשראת האור והשכינה שרואים הנביאים במראה הנבואה, כמו שנאמר: והנה תנור עשן ולפיד אש אשר עבר בין הגזרים האלה (Bereishit 15:17).

וזה היה במראה הנבואה, משום שבפתיחת הסיפור נאמר: ותרדמה נפלה על אברם, והנה אימה חשכה גדלה נפלת עליו.

According to the Rambam, the Brit Bein HaBetarim never physically happened. There were no animals, no pieces, no fire and no smoke: **it all happened in Avraham's mind.** His proof: *a deep sleep fell upon Avram*. The Rabbi adds that the episode opens **היה דבר ה' אל אברם במחזה** — it almost says so explicitly; it's no great chiddush.

Why is עבר used for prophecy? Because in prophecy, Hashem's communication **passes through a person's mind**: it begins at a certain moment and ends at a certain moment.

The radio analogy (in the Rambam, the Ramchal, everywhere): prophecy is like tuning a radio. You tune in, but it is very rare to hold the right signal constantly. The Shechinah passes through, and then it goes.

So what are the smoke and fire passing between the pieces? Probably the **firmness and durability of the covenant** (the commentator explains this here; the Rabbi thinks it is straightforward) — perhaps its warmth too. Whatever they signify precisely, the whole thing is happening in Avraham's mind.

ולפי השאלה הזו נאמר: ועברתי בארץ מצרים (Shemot 12:12)

On the night of Pesach, at midnight, people would suddenly experience something extraordinary — and a few moments later it would stop. **It passes through them.**

Meaning 4 — Overreaching: going beyond the limit

והושאל גם למי שעושה מעשה כל שהוא והפריז בו ועבר את גבולו, כמו שנאמר: הייתי כאיש שכור, וכגבר עברו יין (Yirmiyahu 23:9).

Yirmiyahu says: I was so zealous for You, Hashem, fighting the false prophets, that I was **like a drunk man — like a man whom wine has "passed over"**. A little wine is good; drink too much and it has passed the limit, and you're drunk. *I overreached; perhaps I went too far.*

This is the only meaning not used in the chapter. If it's the one you forget, that's fine. We need 1, 2, 3 and 5.

Meaning 5 — Skipping one target and aiming at another: diversion

והושאל גם למי שדילג על מטרה כלשהי וכיוון מטרה אחרת, או תכלית אחרת.

You can pass *across* something (like Yaakov passing before his family) — or pass *over* it: skip it. I'm going 1, 2, 3, and then I jump over 4 and land on 5. **I have diverted.** You create a diversion — perhaps a misapprehension.

והוא ירה החצי להעברו (Shmuel I 20:36)

Haftarat Machar Chodesh, which we read a week ago. David doesn't know where he stands with Shaul; if he comes, Shaul may kill him. So Yonatan arranges a code: the way he shoots the

arrows will tell David whether to come back or to run.

- **Other Rishonim** read **להעברו** as meaning 4: he shot the arrow **further than expected** — overreaching — as the signal to flee.
- **The Rambam** does not. He reads it as meaning 5: there was a **lad** with Yonatan, who must not catch on to the secret code. Yonatan shot the arrow so as **to divert the lad's attention** — to give him a misapprehension of what was really going on between David and Yonatan.

The five meanings — summary

#	Meaning	Example	Used in Ch. 21?
1	Physical movement across space	**והוא עבר לפניהם**	Yes
2	Proclaiming; sound and rumour spreading	**ויעברו קול במחנה**	Yes
3	A prophetic experience passing through the mind	**ולפיד אש אשר עבר בין הגזרים**	Yes
4	Overreaching a limit	**וכגבר עברו יין**	**No**
5	Skipping, diverting, creating a misapprehension	**והוא ירה החצי להעברו**	Yes

Doron's question: what does עבירה mean?

Doron: when we say someone does an **עבירה**, is that meaning 4 — going beyond what you were meant to do — or meaning 5 — diverting from the path? **The Rabbi:** "Wow, excellent. I actually never put it together."

The Rabbi thought **עבירה** as a noun for sin is probably **rabbinic**, not biblical. If so, it can't mean physical passing (1), proclaiming (2) or prophecy (3) — so it must be **4 (overreaching) or 5 (diverting)**.

But Doron pointed out that the verb is used in Devarim, for breaking the covenant:

לעבר בריתו — וילך ויעבד אלהים אחרים וישתחו להם

The Rabbi: of course — **לא עברתי ממצותיך ולא שכחתי** (Devarim 26:13).

I didn't "pass" Your mitzvot — not physical, not prophetic, not proclaiming. **So it must be 4 or 5. And why didn't the Rambam discuss it?**

Doron: it's almost as if the brit is a physical thing that you cross over — perhaps from the Brit Bein HaBetarim. **The Rabbi:** but that covenant isn't physical. Very interesting — **he wrote it down to come back to at the end of the chapter**, together with several other words he wants to think about.

The Rabbi to those listening on YouTube: it's lovely when people come in person so we can have a dialogue — but if you are listening and have questions, **and more importantly thoughts to add, like this one**, contact him through YouTube or by phone. *This is a conversation to keep going.*

Part Two — Interpretation 1: The Rambam's Preferred Reading

The class's guesses

Which of the five meanings will the Rambam use for **ויעבר ה' על פניו ויקרא**?

- **Yehuda:** meaning **3** — a prophetic experience.
- **Maor:** meaning **5** — by elimination (1 is corporeal; 2 doesn't fit), and because perhaps Moshe went too far in trying to comprehend. **The Rabbi:** that reasoning is really meaning **4** (overreaching) — but **5 is right, though not for that reason.**
- **Doron: 3** feels the most natural.

The Rambam

לדעתי, דברי "ויעבר ה' על פניו" הם לפי השאלה הזאת — the fifth meaning.

וכינוי הגוף ב"פניו" חוזר עליו — "his face" refers to **Hashem**.

Question	The Rambam's answer
1. **What is עבר?**	**Meaning 5 — diversion**
2. **Whose face?**	**Hashem's**
3. **How to read it?**	**ויקרא ה'** — *and Hashem called*: **"ה', אל רחום וחנון..."**
4. **The Thirteen Attributes?**	**Hashem's "back"**: the ways He is manifested in the world

Put together: Moshe asked, *show me Your face.* Hashem said, **לא תוכל לראות את פני**, *you can't see My face* — **וראית את אחרי**, *you will see My back.* How did that happen? **ויעבר ה' על פניו — Hashem diverted Moshe from trying to understand Hashem's face. ויקרא ה' — and Hashem called out the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy. The Thirteen Attributes are Hashem's back.**

Why are they His "back"? Because **they are the ways Hashem is manifested in this world.** As we will learn when we reach **ייחוד ה'**: **there are no thirteen parts of God. There is only one God.** "Thirteen attributes" means **thirteen ways in which His presence is manifested in the world** — and **understanding Hashem through the way He acts in the world is seeing His back.** You won't understand My essence; you can't. I divert you from My face, and give you instead the way I act in this world. *"This changes everything."*

What this means for how we say it

We say this verse constantly. At Selichot each day, Mondays and Thursdays, **26 times on Yom Kippur**, twice daily in Shacharit and Mincha (for Sephardim) — **a good 500 times** between Rosh Chodesh Elul and Yom Kippur. **What are people thinking when they scream ויעבר ה' על פניו ויקרא?** Or the chazanim who go on and on? Whose face? What passing?

- **Bowing.** Most people take **פניו** as **Moshe's** face, which is why people **bow down** at **ויעבר ה' על פניו** — Hashem is passing before your face, so out of kavod you bow. **On the Rambam's reading, there is nothing to bow for**: the verse means something completely different — *Hashem diverted Moshe from God's face.*

- **The chant.** The way it is sung (especially in the Spanish & Portuguese tradition, but everyone does it) — **ויעבר ה' על פניו ויקרא, ה' ה'...** — is wrong on this reading. It is **ויקרא ה'** — *Hashem called* — and what He called begins **ה' אל רחום וחנון**: My Thirteen Attributes, which are My back. (More on this at the end of the chapter.)

The Chachamim's support: Hashem wrapped Himself

וכך פירשו חכמים שפניו... וגם כי אמרו זאת באגדות שאין במקומן — הרי יש בכך חיזוק לדעתנו.

The Rambam knows most people read **פניו** as Moshe's face, so he brings a proof that the Chachamim read it as God's — even if they said it in an Aggadic context:

"ויעבר ה' על פניו ויקרא" — אמר רבי יוחנן: אלמלא מקרא כתוב, אי אפשר לאומרו. מלמד שנתעטף הקדוש ברוך הוא כשליח צבור, והראה לו למשה סדר תפלה. (Rosh Hashanah 17b)

(This is one of the reasons Ashkenazim wear a tallit for Selichot.) **What has a tallit to do with it?** When you wrap a tallit, **you pass it around yourself** — it covers the body. So if the Chachamim said Hashem *wrapped* Himself, they must have read **על פניו** as **Hashem's own** "face": He passed the tallit around Himself. **At least one Aggadic reading takes פניו as God's face.**

The Rambam explains

וביאור הדבר לדעתי, במה שנראה לי: שמשה עליו השלום ביקש השגה מסוימת — והיא שכינה אותה "פנים" בדבריו "ופני לא יראו" — והובטח לו השגה פחותה ממה שביקש, והיא שכינה "ראיית אחור": "וראית את אחרי". וכבר עמדנו על זה במשנה תורה.

אם כן, הוא אומר כאן שהשם יתעלה הסתיר ממנו את ההשגה המכונה "פנים", ועבר הלאה לעניין אחר — כלומר ידיעת המעשים המיוחסים אליו יתעלה, שהם נחשבים עניינים רבים.

Moshe asked for a very high intellectual attainment — "the face". He was promised something lower — "the back". Hashem withheld the "face", **and passed on to another matter**: **knowledge of the actions attributed to Him**, which people think of as many different things. **That is the back of God.**

The same idea in Mishneh Torah

Right at the beginning, in **Hilchot Yesodei HaTorah (1:10)**, after establishing that God has no body:

מהו זה שביקש משה רבינו להשיג כשאמר: הראני נא את כבודך? ביקש לידע אמתת המצאו של הקדוש ברוך הוא, עד שיהא ידוע בלבו כמו ידיעת אחד מן האנשים שראה פניו ונחקקה צורתו בלבו...

The Rabbi's illustration: we're talking to each other now; when I close the computer, **I'll still have the image of your face in my head.** Moshe wanted to know God like that — the essence of His existence.

...והשיבו הקדוש ברוך הוא שאין כח בדעת האדם החי, שהוא מחובר מגוף ונפש, להשיג אמתת דבר זה. ... ועל דבר זה אמר הכתוב: וראית את אחרי ופני לא יראו.

No living human, made of body and soul, can grasp this. (Mishneh Torah doesn't interpret **ופני לא יראו** in quite the same words, but it is the same idea.)

Why "covered by My palm": the danger of going too far

בדברי "הסתיר ממנו", כוונתי לומר שהשגה זו נסתרת ונמנעת מטבעה.

"Hashem withheld it" doesn't mean it would have been possible otherwise. It is **by nature** impossible for a human being.

וכל אדם שלם, כאשר שכלו נקשר בדבר שטבעו להשיגו, וישאף להשגה נוספת מעבר לכך — עלולה השגתו להשתבש, או שימות, כפי שאבאר בפרק הבא — אלא אם ילווה אליו סיוע אלוהי, כמו שנאמר: ושכתי כפי עליך עד עברי.

When a person reaches for spiritual, metaphysical, philosophical attainment **beyond what his mind can grasp**, he can **go mad, or die** — unless **Hashem helps him**: **ושכתי כפי עליך עד עברי**, *I will cover you with My palm until I have passed.*

The four who entered the Pardes (Chagigah 14b): **Ben Azzai** died; **Ben Zoma** went mad; **Elisha ben Avuya** became a heretic (to an extent, also a kind of madness); **Rabbi Akiva** went in correctly and came out in peace. When you try to reach this level, be careful not to go too far — and sometimes you need to pray for Hashem's help so that you don't.

"Jerusalem syndrome": there are more people who have lost their way roaming Jerusalem, proportionally — anyone who has learned in yeshiva there has seen it. **Why?** Because Jerusalem is where we come close to Hashem, and people can go too far spiritually and philosophically. *(The Rabbi stressed: this is still meaning 5, not meaning 4.)*

The whole narrative on Interpretation 1

הראני נא את כבדך — Show me Your glory, Your face.

לא תוכל לראות את פני, כי לא יראני האדם וחי — No human can see My face and live.

הנה מקום אתי, ונצבת על הצור — There is an intellectual standing with Me: stand constantly on the Rock, the origin of the universe.

והיה בעבר כבדי — **I** means God Himself, as the Rambam will say in a later **כבודי** here) When — **divert you** from My face to My back (chapter

ושמתיך בנקרת הצור, ושכתי כפי עליך עד עברי — I will **protect you intellectually** while I divert you. Even seeing just My back, you could go mad; I will protect you so that you don't, from the intellectual experience you are about to have.

והסרתי את כפי, וראית את אחרי — then I will remove My palm, and you will see My back: **the way I act.**

And then it happens:

וירד ה' בענן, ויתיצב עמו שם — Hashem rests His presence with Moshe, permanently.

ויעבר ה' על פניו — Hashem **diverts** Moshe from His face.

ויקרא ה' — Hashem **calls out** His attributes, His back: **"ה' אל רחום וחנון, ארך אפים ורב חסד ואמת, נצר חסד לאלפים, נשא עון ופשע וחטאה ונקה."**

"You can just jump out of excitement when you learn this."

A question from the class: what does it mean that God Himself is "passing" in **בעבר כבודי**? **The Rabbi: בעבר** means *when I divert* — **כבודי** is Hashem doing the diverting, not the destination. *When I, God, divert you, I will place My palm upon you until I finish taking you from My face to My*

back. **Part of the confusion is the chapter break** (chapter divisions are a Christian concept): **the end of chapter 33 tells Moshe what will happen; chapter 34 is it happening.**

Part Three — Interpretations 2 and 3: Targum Onkelos

The Rambam **accepts** Onkelos's interpretation — he calls it good.

Onkelos's method

והנה התרגום נהג כמנהגו בדברים כאלו: דהיינו שכל דבר שאנו מוצאים אותו מיוחס לה' ויש בו הגשמה או ספק הגשמה — הוא מפרש אותו בצורת שם ונסמך, כך שכינוי הגוף יהיה לדבר שהוא נסמך לשם...

Wherever a verse attributes to Hashem something corporeal — or even possibly corporeal — **Onkelos adds a word**, so that the physical action belongs to **a created manifestation**, not to God. *(Rav Saadia does exactly the same, as we learned in Emunot VeDeot; interestingly, the Rambam doesn't mention him here.)*

Verse	Onkelos
how can Hashem *stand*? — (Yaakov's ladder) **והנה ה' נצב עליו** He has no body	**יקרא דה' מעתד עלוהי** — **the glory of Hashem** stood upon it
Lavan and Yaakov's pact — Hashem will) **יצף ה' ביני ובינך** ?watch between us; does He have eyes)	**יסך מימרא דה'** — **the word of Hashem** will watch (hashgachah)

כך נהג אונקלוס עליו השלום... וכן עשה לגבי מה שנאמר "ויעבר ה' על פניו": ואעבר ה' שכינתיה על אפוהי וקרא.

Hashem passed His Shechinah before him, and called.

אם כן, לדעתו הדבר שעבר הוא נברא, בלי ספק; והוא פירש את כינוי הגוף ב"פניו" שמוסב על משה רבינו.

Interpretation 2 (2A): a created light passing in Moshe's presence

Question	Onkelos (2A)
1. **What is עבר?**	**Meaning 1 — physical passing** — of a **created manifestation** (the Shechinah, the glory), not of God
2. **Whose face?**	**Moshe's**
3. **How to read it?**	Hashem called the attributes — **ויקרא ה'**

And on this reading, bowing makes sense. The Shechinah, a created light, passes before Moshe; we replicate it, and bow as it passes our face.

"על פניו" means "in his presence"

ולפי זה, פירוש "על פניו" — בנוכחותו, כמו שנאמר: ותעבר המנחה על פניו. (Bereishit 32:22)

This is very important. On the Rambam's reading, **פניו** is a literal "face" — Hashem's face, as opposed to His back. On Onkelos's reading, **על פניו** doesn't mean Moshe's literal face, but **his**

presence. The proof: Yaakov's gifts to Esav (we'll read it in Vayishlach in a few weeks) passed **על פניו** — not over his face, but **in front of him, in his presence**.

Interpretation 3 (2B): a prophetic vision

But why does the Rambam choose this verse, of all the verses about gifts passing? Look at **the end of it**:

ותעבר המנחה על פניו, והוא לן בלילה ההוא במחנה.

He was sleeping. So Onkelos can also be read with **meaning 3**: **the Shechinah passed "before him" — in a prophetic vision.** Not a created, physical light at all: **it happened in Moshe's mind.** The Rambam doesn't say this here, but **he says it explicitly at the end of the chapter**, and that is why he brings this verse.

Question	Onkelos (2B)
1. **What is עבר?**	**Meaning 3 — a prophetic experience** passing through Moshe's mind
2. **Whose face?**	**Moshe's** — "in his presence"
3. **How to read it?**	Hashem called — **ויקרא ה'**

Support for Onkelos from the verse itself

ואישוש לפירוש אונקלוס ניתן למצוא בדברי הכתוב: "והיה בעבר כבדי" — הרי שם נאמר במפורש שמה שיעבור הוא דבר מיוחס לו יתעלה, לא עצמותו... ועל הכבוד הזה נאמר "עד עברי" ו"ויעבר על פניו".

The verse does say **"when My glory passes"** — which implies that what passes is **something of God**, His **kavod**, not God Himself. **The Rambam will say (in a chapter in the 60s) that he can understand כבודי as God Himself** — which is how Interpretation 1 reads it — **but the simple meaning of כבודי is "the glory of"**, which supports Onkelos.

Summary

Five meanings of עבר: (1) physical movement across space; (2) proclaiming — sound and rumour spreading; (3) a prophetic experience passing through the mind; (4) overreaching a limit (not used in this chapter); (5) skipping one target for another — **diversion**.

Three interpretations of ויעבר ה' על פניו ויקרא so far:

	Meaning of עבר	Whose face	What passes / what it means
1. The Rambam (preferred)	**5 — diversion**	**Hashem's**	Hashem diverted Moshe from His **face** (essence) to His **back** (His ways in the world); **ויקרא ה'** — Hashem called the Thirteen Attributes, which are that "back"
2. Onkelos (2A)	**1 — physical passing**	**Moshe's** ("in his presence")	A **created** Shechinah, a light, passed before Moshe; then Hashem called
3. Onkelos (2B)	**3 — prophetic experience**	**Moshe's** ("in his presence")	The Shechinah passed **in Moshe's mind**, in a prophetic vision (**והוא לן בלילה ההוא**)

The Thirteen Attributes are not thirteen parts of God — there is only one God — **but thirteen ways He is manifested in the world.** No human can know His essence (Yesodei HaTorah 1:10); reaching beyond what the mind can grasp leads to madness or death without Hashem's help (**ושכתי כפי עליך**). And on the Rambam's reading, **bowing at ויעבר** and **chanting "ויקרא, ה' ה'"** don't fit the verse.

Coming Up

- **Next week:** a quick review of these three; **Interpretation 4** — the Rambam's own reading using the Targum's principle of adding a word, but completely different; the **Rambam's conclusions** on all four; a **comparison chart**; and back to **עבירה** and the other words the Rabbi has noted (**לא עברתי ממצותיך**, **לעבר בריתו**).
- Chapter 21 should be finished in about 45 minutes, and perhaps the short **Chapter 22** in the last 10–15.
- **During the week:** reflect on this, read over the notes. We say this verse so often in tefillah that there are plenty of opportunities to think about it. *If you're convinced by the Rambam and don't want to bow at ויעבר — that's fine. The point is to think about these three.*

B'Ezrat Hashem

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